

They lack trust in their team members

- Leaders get caught up in all the details
- Leaders feel the sense of a loss of control
- Leaders "worry" about quality

Knowing when and to whom you should delegate to

Delegating can be especially helpful in the following situations:

- When the task offers a valuable training opportunity for a team member
- When a team member has more knowledge or experience related to the task than you
- When the task is recurring and all team members should be trained
- When the task is of low priority and you have higher priority tasks that require your immediate attention

When deciding who to select for the task, you must consider:

- The team members current work load
- The strengths and weaknesses of the team member
- The experience and skill level of the team member

IDEAL - Six steps of delegations. In this section we will review the 6 different steps and approaches for enhancing your delegation skills.

I - Introduce the task

D - Demonstrate clearly what needs to be done

E - Ensure understanding

A - Allocate authority, information and resources

L - Let go

S - Support and monitor

Introduce the task

- Determine the tasks to be delegated
- Determine the tasks to retain
- Select who you will delegate the task to

When you introduce the task use "What-Why" statements like "I want you to do ... because you ..."

Demonstrate Clearly

- Show examples of previous work
- Explain objectives
- Discuss timelines, expected outcomes and then set a deadline

Ensuring Understanding

- Provide clear communication
- Ask the team member if they need additional clarification

- Secure commitment that the team member can achieve the objective
- Collaboratively determine methods for follow up

Allocate authority, information and resources

- Grant authority to determine process, not desired outcomes
- Provide access to all the information sources
- Refer team members to specific resources and other team members that have been assisting with the task in the past or present
- Provide any appropriate training necessary to ensure success

Let go

- Communicate to the broader audience the team members authority and ownership of task
- Step back, let the team member get to work
- Don't allow yourself to engage in reverse delegation or step in take over (unless the task is completely going off the track or potentially going to miss the deadline by a significant amount of time) Reverse delegation is a term that describes a situation whereby a manager delegates a task to their direct reports, but only to take it back, for one reason or another, to work on it sometime later. There are two ways, forced and unforced, that reverse delegation may take place.

Support and Monitor

- Schedule follow-up meetings
- Review progress
- Assist, when requested
- Avoid interference
- Publicly praise progress and completion
- Encourage problem-solving

Delegation Stressors

"Why do Managers...?"

- Loss of control - If you train your team members to apply the same criteria as you would yourself, then they will be exercising your control on your behalf.
- Too much time spent on explaining the tasks: The amount of time you spent up front is, in fact, great. But, continued use of the team member may free you up to complete more complex tasks and/or gain you some time for yourself.
- Compromising your own value - By successfully delegating to team members, your value to the department, division and GitLab will grow at a faster rate as you will have more time to do more things.

Delegation Obstacles

- Lack of support - Manager and team members must be fully supportive of the delegation efforts in order to be successful
- Failure to plan - Taking the time to follow the steps for delegation can avoid any pitfalls that might otherwise be overlooked

- Lack of communication - Communicating the plan in a clear and precise manner prevents errors caused by miscommunication
- Fear of relinquishing control - Management may be resistant to delegating at first, but delegation can build trust and morale among managers and team members
- Micromanagement - Micromanagement prevents team members from completing their assigned tasks and defeats the purpose of delegation
- Interruptions - Managing our time is a key attribute to increasing the managerial output of the teams we lead. Interruptions can occur a lot. Ask yourself how you can strive toward regularity and prevent stops and starts in your day.

Signs of Micromanagement

Micromanaging occurs when a manager assigns a task to a team member, but prevents the team member from successfully completing the task on their own. Micromanagers usually:

- Resist delegating
- Prevent team members from making decisions
- Revoke tasks after they have been assigned
- Avoid letting team members work independently

How to avoid Micromanagement

- Clearly define the roles and responsibilities of managers and team members
- Create a written plan and timeline
- Include scheduled meetings and evaluations rather than frequent "check ins" that can be viewed as micromanaging
- Allow team members and managers to openly communicate any concerns or questions they may have

Consequences of poor delegation

- Information and decision-making is not shared by the group
- Leaders become tired or burnt out
- If a leader leaves the group, no one has the experience needed to carry on
- Team or group morale becomes low and people become frustrated and feel powerless
- The skills and knowledge of the group/division/department are concentrated in a few people
- New team members do not find any meaningful ways to contribute to the work or growth of the group

Conclusion

Practice makes perfect. It gets easier the more you do it! Below are a few useful articles for managers regarding the importance of delegation.

- Managers Must Delegate Effectively to Develop Employees
- Why Aren't You Delegating
- Management Tips: 10 Reasons To Delegate
- The Benefits of Delegation and Why Most Leaders Under-Delegate
- How to Delegate Tasks Effectively and Why it is Important

Books to consider reading

- If You Want It Done Right, You Don't Have to Do It Yourself! The Power of Effective Delegation
- The Busy Manager's Guide to Delegation
- The Art of Delegation: Maximize Your Time, Leverage Others, and Instantly Increase Profits
- How to Delegate - Essential Managers series

SECTION: leadership/high-output-management.md

Introduction

At GitLab, one of our favorite books is, "High Output Management" by Andrew Grove. The book provides a comprehensive overview of a manager's role and purpose. Our co-founder, Sid, applied many of the concepts covered when partnering with the People team to design management and people practices for GitLab. On this page, we will cover some of the key topics covered in the book and what they mean for people leaders.

Applying High Output Management

{{< youtube "CHs8NxRSGPw" >}}

Sid and the Learning and Development team discuss High Output Management during a CEO Handbook Learning Session. In the video, we explore how the book shaped GitLab management processes and policies.

Topics covered include:

1. Why the book is one of Sid's favorites.
1. Why dual reporting structures lead to matrix organizations and how GitLab maintains a no-matrix organization.
1. Why 1-1 meetings are fundamental to management.
1. Enabling the direct report to show initiative in their career and performance.
1. The importance of emotional intelligence in management based on task-relevant maturity.
1. Why training the team should be the manager's job.

> If there is one management book you should read, it is High Output Management. A lot of GitLab policies are directly from the book. Managers can learn that the most challenging aspect of management, is managing their time to make decisions and achieve results. This book will teach you how.

Team members can expense the book if they choose to purchase.

High Output Management

The central thesis is that a manager's objective is to increase the output of the work of those on their team. At GitLab, managers are expected to lead their teams to achieve results. Therefore, a manager should choose high-leverage activities that have a multiplicative impact on the overall output of the team. GitLab moves fast. There are meetings, issues and MRs to review, 1-1s, informal communication, and much more. One way for a manager to be successful is

by providing a clear direction to a team by applying a small amount of the time that yields a tremendous value in terms of the output of the team.

For example, managers at GitLab can:

1. Delegate tasks through Issue boards. Issue boards can serve as a project management tool to plan, organize, and visualize a workflow for a team.
1. Decline Meetings in Favor of Async. Meetings are useful for building rapport and moving projects forward. Managers can be role models of our bias towards asynchronous communication by declining meetings in favor of async. They can also be role models by only scheduling meetings where it is necessary to review a concrete proposal or to move forward a series of asynchronous discussion points.
1. Making decisions by applying the best of both hierarchical and consensus on your team. Allow the person on your team that does the work to make the decisions, the Directly Responsible Individual.
1. Elicit peak performance through motivation. Managers can improve output on their team by applying motivation, building trust, and training.

Application of Individual KPIs

A topic covered in High Output Management is for managers to choose Key Performance Indicators to help their team achieve results. Managers are responsible for ensuring their teams have KPIs linked to the company OKRs. Managers can also create both team and individual KPIs to measure what gets done. If people leaders set a goal around a desired outcome for their people, the chances of that outcome occurring can be higher; simply because you have committed to managing and measuring direct report progress towards it.

When you set goals and KPIs with direct reports, make sure they align with your team's overall strategy and KPIs, which aligns with the organization's overall strategy.

Performance Management

In the book, the author describes applying async practices to begin performance discussions. Managers use a regularly scheduled 1-1 meeting to discuss performance with a direct report. They prepare a document before the meeting with all of the key points, areas of strength, areas of development, and a plan for the future. This gives the direct report time to digest before the performance discussion. The synchronous meeting time can be used by the direct report to ask clarifying questions on the feedback. Managers are able to focus their attention on key points rather than covering all the points in one meeting.

SECTION: leadership/in-person.md

GitLab Onsites

- > GitLab Onsites
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> Dedicated time for all-remote teams to come together in person to build trust

As a leader in all-remote work, it's important that we recognize the value and impact of time spent in the same location. Meaningful time spent together influences the trust and results our teams build. Co-located companies often gather for offsites to connect in a new location. In our all-remote environment, we call in-person team meetings onsite.

This page is an onsite planning resource for people managers at GitLab. Use these suggestions to guide the way you plan in-person time for your team. Our additional considerations for in person time advise the wider GitLab community on how to make the most of time spent at conferences, in person meetings, and other types of meetups.

Leading an onsite for your team might be outside your comfort zone. The resources on this page will equip you to feel confident organizing an in-person team event. Lean into the skills that make you a great manager as you plan.

After your team onsite, we hope you'll feel:

- 1. United on common team goals
- 1. Motivated to achieve results
- 1. Connected with shared understanding and trust
- 1. Trusting and connected with those with whom you work most closely

Let us help you plan your onsite

The GitLab Talent Engagement team is here to support your onsite planning. We can help you plan activities and make suggestions on how you can best spend this time together in person. To request this custom support, please open an issue [here](#) using the onsite-support template.

Please note this does not include support for booking or scheduling onsite events and locations.

Prepare

Consider the following as you start planning your onsite:

Set a goal

What do you want your team to get out of this time spent together? As a manager, setting an intention for this time is vital. You need to develop a shared understanding of why the team is traveling to be together and have a clear way to measure success of the onsite.

Use these sample goals to get started. Personalize your final goal based on your team in this current moment. What is going on for the next fiscal year? Has your team struggled in the past with microaggressions, difficulty working together, or transitioning to new leadership? If you tailor your goal to exactly what your team is needing most, you'll see greater engagement and results.

Sample goals:

1. Build trust and get to know each other so our team can work more efficiently together when we're all remote.
1. Develop a 3 year vision and clarify individual opportunity for contribution and growth within that vision.
1. Collaborate on a solution for a challenging and persistent issue our team faces.

Plan transparently

Be transparent in your planning to maximize both attendance and engagement:

1. Ask for input from your team early and often: What do folks on your team want to do during their time together? What are they not interested in?
1. Set expectations: Leave nothing as a surprise. Build psychological safety by planning out in the open so folks know what to expect.
1. Share resources: Share resources like our expense handbook, travel handbook, support for nursing mothers, and considerations for working while traveling.
1. Plan in advance: Some functions and roles at GitLab are accustomed to work travel - others are not. Give time to plan and organize schedules to maximize attendance and presence.

Develop a shared reality

Spending time during a team meeting to set norms for your onsite will begin to develop shared expectations for your time together.

1. Assign prework: Depending on the goals you've set and the activities you've planned, assign prework to help your team prepare. This might be a video, article, or activity to complete prior to meeting in person.
1. Clarify expectations around attendance: Make it clear that remote participation will be offered, but in person attendance is preferred whenever possible.

Activity Planning

The all-remote structure at GitLab is efficient and collaborative. It works really well for problem solving, independent work, and all forms of collaboration - not to mention things like getting up to date on GitLab to-dos and Slack messages.

Time spent together in person has its own benefits, too. It's great for building trust, getting to know members of your team, and creative brainstorm discussions.

Review the resources below for guidance on what to prioritize when your team is together in person, and what you might save for when you're back in your home office.

Team Building

Make the most of onsites with intentional time to get to know one another.

1. Set and iterate group norms: Spend 5-10 minutes at the start of each day to set and review group norms. Decide together things like work you're going to set aside, if/when you'll take breaks as a group, and how you'll communicate during each activity. These might be similar to norms your team follows on all-remote team meetings, but recognize that it might be different -

like making sure everyone knows where the restroom is and that everyone has a comfortable seat or space to work.

1. Personality assessments: Increased awareness of our own strengths and working styles helps us work more collaboratively with others. Use a framework like social styles, Clifton Strengths Assessment, or the Enneagram Assessment. Assign the assessment as prework then have a discussion to share results.

1. Ice Breakers: Don't cringe - ice breakers don't have to be super cheesy or put people on the spot. A great ice breaker gets authentic conversation started. Here are a few ideas to get you started. Be mindful of how underrepresented groups and neurodiverse team members might feel during these activities.

- Conversation Deck: Purchase a deck like The Teamwork Game or this Best Self Question Deck. Pick a card to start a conversation in small groups, then share.

- Temperature Check: ask folks to share how they are feeling to start the day on a color or number scale. Give space to elaborate if comfortable.

1. Incorporate flexible social time: Plan team lunch or dinner, exercise classes, group walks, cooking classes, or tours to explore the city where you're meeting. Be mindful of mobility limitations and your team members' individual needs.

1. Balance team building with independent time: We all need space to recharge. Avoid booking each day solid with activities. Ensure there is time for folks to return to their hotel room or spend time alone to feel ready for each day's activities.

Consider Utilizing Design Thinking Exercises

Design thinking is a non-linear, iterative process that teams use to understand users, challenge assumptions, redefine problems and create innovative solutions to prototype and test. (Source: Interaction Design). What makes design thinking unique is that it's a user-centric, solution-based approach to problem solving. The focus is on the solution, rather than the problem. Design thinking gives opportunity for everyone to contribute and can help develop a growth mindset.

Design thinking directly supports our GitLab values of Results, Collaboration, and Efficiency. We balance being ambitious along with a focus on boring solutions - both of which are solutions-oriented.

Listen to Tim Brown speak about the Design Thinking process in this TedTalk.

{{< youtube UAinLaT42xY >}}

Regardless of what your team is working on during time in person - whether it be long term planning, high stakes problem solving, or new idea generation - you can apply design thinking activities to achieve results. Here are some suggested activities you can explore:

1. Roses, Buds, Thorns activity: Gather feedback on what is and isn't working, then identify new opportunities.

1. Eisenhower Matrix: Map top priorities to set realistic goals.

1. Empathy Map: Apply emotional intelligence skills to understand the root cause of a problem.

1. Structured Brainstorming: Focus discussion on a specific topic or problem to solve. Set brainstorming norms to stay efficient.

Logistics

Inclusion and remote participation

It's inevitable that some team members won't make it to an onsite. It's critical to think about how you'll include remote participation to ensure that folks aren't missing out on key conversations and team building.

1. Find out in advance who cannot attend. It's important to know this information early so you can plan a successful event.
1. Plan key team discussions in timezones where remote participants can call in.
1. Engaged remote participants in discussion - don't just ask them to listen.
1. Use technology to set yourself up for success - tools like Mural can mimic whiteboards and allow multiple ways to contribute.
1. Ask for consistent feedback. Ensure the structure is working for remote participants and adapt as needed.
1. Set clear boundaries so remote participants don't feel like they need to 'cover' for everyone who is in person.

Outdoor events

It's challenging to include remote participants in team building, especially in an outdoor space. Here are a few special considerations for this:

1. Plan team building that allows for remote participation. For example, in a cooking or painting class, you could accommodate with a Zoom set up so remote participants can follow along. WithConfetti is a great resource for sessions and ideas.
1. Encourage, and provide budget, for remote participants to get together with other remote participants. This could look like a Zoom happy hour, or a shared meal for all remote participants.

Ready to get planning?

The content and suggestions from this page are neatly captured in 2 planning templates. Simply open the template, make a copy, and use this resource to plan your event!

Customize the templates as needed. We suggestion you start with the Onsite Planning Guide to plan, then use the Onsite Attendee Guide to communicate plans to your team.

Onsite Planning Guide

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Onsite Attendee Guide - Know Before you Go

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Additional Resources

1. Travel Guidelines
1. Travel support for nursing mothers
1. Expense Guidelines
1. Considerations for working while traveling

Contribute

Our team member community is the expert on what works for time spent together - so contribute! Open a Merge Request to update this page with your favorite (and least favorite!) ways to spend in person time with your team.

SECTION: leadership/making-decisions.md

Intro to making decisions

On this page, we have outlined how we make decisions at GitLab.

Making decisions

GitLab's values are the guiding principles for our business. They inform hiring, performance management, and promotion assessments. They also guide other decisions that we make. At times, values may be in conflict. To address this, GitLab has a values hierarchy. At the top of this hierarchy is "results". While items higher in the hierarchy don't always override items lower in the hierarchy, this structure guides team members as they weigh decision making alternatives.

GitLab has a decision making process that avoids the short falls of hierarchical and consensus organizations. Hierarchical organizations can make decisions quickly, but aren't great at gathering data. This leads people to say "yes," but have relatively low follow through on their commitments. Consensus organizations are good at gathering data but lack decision making speed. This can lead to projects happening under the radar.

To avoid the undesirable outcomes of hierarchical and consensus organizations, GitLab splits decisions into two phases:

1. A data gathering phase in which folks are actively asked to contribute data and perspectives that can inform decision making. This has the benefits of consensus organizations: everyone can contribute and decision makers benefit from more available data.
1. A decision phase in which an informed individual can make a decision without getting an approval from others. Voting on material decisions shows a lack of informed leadership. The decision phase has the benefit of hierarchical organizations: the person that does the work or their manager decides what to do, so decisions can be made quickly.

These phases don't work if you take a full consensus or hierarchy approach. If you apply consensus in both the data gathering phase and the decision phase, you lose speed. Decisions also stay under the radar as team members try to limit the amount of folks they need to buy-in. If you apply a hierarchy approach in both the data gathering phase and the decision phase, they lose valuable input. We can allow others into our kitchen, because we can always send them out. Inviting people to give input is much easier if you retain the ability to make a decision by yourself.

GitLab's two phase decision making approach depends on aligned team member expectations and clear roles. Contributors can feel ignored when they provide input, but are not included in the decision making progress. They have to accept that the decision maker listened to them, but doesn't owe them an explanation. Otherwise, you lose decision-making speed. To develop this

level of trust, you need clear accountability and expectations for the decision maker.

At GitLab, each decision has an assigned Directly Responsible Individual (DRI). This is the person who leads the work, including data gathering, and makes the decision. The DRI analyzes the data and weighs different options. This requires the DRI to assess the validity and biases of different perspectives and the relevance and strength of data. The DRI should actively seek out input from folks who have meaningful data or experience in the subject area.

The DRI should have the level of seniority and knowledgeability required to gather information and make decisions. While this will vary with the complexity and potential impact of a decision, a DRI who is well matched to the ask gives team members confidence in an informed and knowledgeable hierarchy. Team members will be more confident that their feedback has been considered and more likely to agree or disagree and commit with a decision.

At GitLab, DRIs can make decisions that other team members disagree with. We say that collaboration is not consensus and people are not their work. A DRI may make a decision that results in (and is hence the cause of) negative feelings, but the DRI isn't expected to make the popular decision and the person, the DRI, is not the decision that has been made. The DRI should consider input and make an informed decision, but the DRI is not responsible for how people feel. Once a DRI has made a decision, team members are asked to disagree, commit, and disagree.

> If good decision-making appears complicated, that's because it is and has been for a long time. Let me quote from Alfred Sloan, who spent a lifetime preoccupied with decision-making: "Group decisions do not always come easily. There is a strong temptation for the leading officers to make decisions themselves without the sometimes onerous process of discussion."

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> - Chapter 5: Decisions, Decisions of High Output Management by Andy Grove

Why DRIs, not project managers

DRIs are not project or program managers unless they are team members who work with external organizations. Everyone at GitLab should be a manager of one. Team members need to develop their daily priorities to achieve goals. Individual contributors need to manage themselves. Self-leadership is an essential skill for all team members. If you manage yourself you have a much greater freedom to make decisions, and those decisions are based on deep knowledge of the situation. Folks who cannot be a manager of one struggle at GitLab. Assigning a project manager/coordinator/case manager/etc. to something is an indicator that something is wrong as DRIs should be equipped to manage their work. The notable exception to this is working with external organizations, for example in the Professional Services organization. External organizations don't have our style of working so we need to adapt to their style of working to make it successful. Also working along organizational boundaries is much harder to begin with.

Tips for folks who are contributing to decisions

1. Use data, use cases, and historic examples when you contribute information.
1. Do not use personal opinions or attacks.
1. Encourage participation from others who may have useful data to share.

Tips for DRIs in making decisions

1. Make data-driven decisions.

1. When analyzing data for a decision, focus on growth and trends. Most of the time cumulative graphs shouldn't be used because a standalone cumulative chart can be misleading as it goes up even if growth is flat or declining. If you must show a cumulative graph always include growth and trends on the same slide.

1. Be aware of your unconscious biases and emotional triggers.

1. When making decisions, explicitly acknowledge the quality/quantity of the data that is available for the decision. Resist using poor data to justify judgment calls. It is ok to make a judgment call with limited data, but make sure that is known.

1. Consider environments that do not allow reliable data collection. According to research by the Harvard Business Review, "experience and knowledge of leaders in the subject matter still outperforms purely data-driven approaches."

Decision Proposals for Collaborating and Communicating

Decisions that require input, buy-in, or awareness of others should be accompanied by a brief, documented proposal. This can be captured in an agenda, issue, or Google Doc. Proposals should include SPADE Decision Making components. At GitLab, we should share the following:

1. Setting

1. Precisely define the "what." What decision is being made? What is the scope of the decision? Does this impact the product, the platform, or the entire company? Be as specific as possible.

1. Be clear on the "when." Explain the why of the "when." Why that date? Why that duration?

1. Explain the "why." Clearly establishing the why is the key to the setting.

1. Why is this smallest and fastest? A statement on how you are taking an iterative approach. Otherwise said, could this decision be broken into even smaller parts? If not, why not?

1. People

1. Note who was consulted in the decision and proposal alternatives. Documenting who was involved and their role in the decision (consulted or DRI). This helps the team visually see if we have been inclusive in the data gathering phase.

1. Alternatives

1. What alternative approaches were considered, including the one that you recommend? This is also a section to link designs or other external documentation.

1. Decision

1. Which alternative or option was chosen? This should be updated following DRIs decision.

1. Explain

1. Details for your recommendation. Justification for why your preferred path was recommended over others. When appropriate and possible, this should include a recommendation grounded in data.

We have an issue template that captures these elements: <https://gitlab.com/gitlab-com/www-gitlab-com/-/blob/master/.gitlab/issuetemplates/decision-template.md>.

E-Group Conversation on Making Decisions

GitLab E-Group and the Learning and Development team discussed strategies on making decisions

as part of the CEO Handbook Learning Session.

Topics covered include:

- 1. Living our Transparency value when making decisions
- 1. How to improve our ability to Iterate
- 1. Applying the GitLab values hierarchy in making decisions
- 1. How the DRI enables decisions making
- 1. When to use consensus when gathering information and when to use hierarchy when making decisions
- 1. Importance of making team members feel safe when making decisions
- 1. Why team members making the most mistakes are likely to be the highest performers
- 1. Making decisions in the face of uncertainty

{{< youtube "-by6ohMliM" >}}

SECTION: leadership/managing-burnout.md

Manager Guide: Identifying & Addressing Burnout

With GitLab's results-driven culture, the demands of product innovation around AI, the fast-paced and ever-evolving business environment, our organization recognizes the crucial balance between achieving ambitious goals and maintaining the well-being of our team members.

Defining Burnout

The World Health Organization defines Burnout as "a syndrome conceptualized as resulting from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed. It is characterized by three dimensions: feelings of energy depletion or exhaustion; increased mental distance from one's job, or feelings of negativism or cynicism related to one's job"

Goal

The primary objective of this resource is to set expectations of leaders when it comes to managing burnout and to provide practical strategies to proactively identify and address signs of burnout. People leaders play a key role in ensuring a healthy, productive, and engaged workforce.

This guide serves as a toolkit for fostering a supportive work culture where team members feel recognized for high performance and motivated to excel, without compromising on their mental and physical health. We encourage managers to utilize these insights in their regular interactions and decision-making processes, adapting them to their team's unique dynamics and needs. By doing so, we aim not only to enhance our team's overall well-being but also to sustain GitLab's innovative momentum and long-term success.

Resource

- Modern Health provides an interactive walkthrough centered on burnout prevention and designed

for people managers. Preventing Burnout in Team Members (10 min) is included for all GitLab team members. If this is your first time using GitLab's Modern Health benefit, you can follow guidance for team member registration.

- Reflect: What are other ways "burnout" might show up beyond "fatigue"?

Understanding Burnout

Here are some team member considerations inspired by GitLab's culture, values, and ways of working. You'll see some tips, but we'll share more advice and talking points below:

- On & Offline:- When working in a remote, heavily asynchronous, collaborative team environment you may not always see and hear early signs of fatigue or burnout. Make it a point to reserve time in regular connections to see how team members are managing workload and boundaries. Even asking directly in a Slack message can be helpful.
- Flexibility: GitLab encourages team members to be directly involved in when, where, and how they get their best work done. Managers still play a key role in allowing space while also remaining dialed into progress, output, and managing capacity.
- Results-driven: Burnout has a direct impact on deliverables and overall results. Managers must continuously strive to improve workload management, output, and their team's well being. This is, in itself, a result of a manager's leadership capability and there should be a sense of ownership of the work for which their team is responsible.
- Common Pitfall: "Taking time away resolves any issues related to burnout." While taking time away is a great way to set boundaries and strike a healthy balance between work and personal time; it's not a catch-all solution. Time away should be supported and modeled by leaders, but leaders also need to recognize that addressing a team member's potential burnout can come from a variety of approaches. This might include coaching on time management, additional targeted feedback, more effective delegation, or goal clarification. Note: Time Away is CRUCIAL to well-being and quality work. This is part of GitLab's culture around work beyond combating burnout.
- Sense of "urgency": Some team members may read this excerpt from GitLab Values.
 - > "At an exponentially-scaling startup, time gained or lost has compounding effects. Try to get the results as fast as possible, but without compromising our other values and ways we communicate, so the compounding of results can begin and we can focus on the next improvement."

...and only hear the "urgency" without recognizing the emphasis GitLab puts on effectively managing work, agency, and family + friends first.

- Ask around: Managers may hear about burnout and workload issues directly from team members, but there may be a need to appropriately source information from cross-functional partners or People Business partners to help understand how team members are feeling around workload.

Resource

- GitLab Handbook: "Recognizing Burnout" (5 min)

Addressing Burnout

- Again, Rest and Time Off are PRODUCTIVE!: With GitLab's recent updates to the paid time off policy, prioritizing time away remains top of mind.
- Workload Management: Managers are expected to delegate work effectively. Doing this effectively means strategically distributing workload and creating space for team members to

express support or push back when needed.

- [] Encourage open dialogue whenever possible
- [] Transparently share workload management strategies and systems
- [] Discuss how workload and demand informs delegation
- Growth & Development: There are several ways to improve/enhance capabilities for managers and team members when it comes to combating burnout through professional development opportunities centered around stress management, time management, and professional counseling.
 - [] Preventative training for the whole team
- Creating a Supportive Work Environment: Foster an environment of open communication and support, encouraging team members to speak up about their challenges.
- Longer-Term Solutions: Encourage participation in wellness programs, explicitly communicate with teams about GitLabs culture of flexible work, and review job/role descriptions for potential stressors and opportunities to address scope.
- Dogfood: Managers must model healthy/balanced working behaviors! Taking time away, sharing challenges and success around effectively managing workload, storytelling centered on output as a result of effective workload management.

Resource to share with team members

Combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety in the remote workplace
Burnout Index: Yerbo's Risk Check

Where to ask questions

You can direct questions to people-managers-and-above Slack channel.

Resource Repository

Below, you can access all the referenced in this guide:

| Reference | Notes |

| :----- | :----- |

|GitLab team members share how to recognize burnout (and how to prevent it) |Audience:
All team members |

|Recognizing Burnout |Audience: All team members |

|Combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety in the remote workplace |Audience: All team
members |

|Yerbo's Risk Check |Managers can share this with their teams. It's recommended that
managers go through this for themselves as well. |

|MentalHealthAware |Audience: All team members |

Additional Resources

Modern Health: Burnout at work can also be influenced by a multitude of experiences happening inside and outside of work. EAP offers benefits the serve a variety of needs.

SECTION: leadership/no-matrix-organization.md

No matrix organization introduction

On this page, we will give an overview of how GitLab operates as a no matrix organization.

"No matrix organization" means that everyone reports to exactly one person. At GitLab we have a simple functional management hierarchy. Technical leadership at GitLab is leadership without a formal reporting line, based on project roles and experience.

No matrix organization overview

1. We believe everyone deserves to report to exactly one person that knows and understands what you do day to day. The benefit of having a technically competent manager is easily the largest positive influence on a typical worker's level of job satisfaction. We have a simple functional hierarchy, everyone has one manager that is experienced in their subject matter that allows them to meaningfully engage with the work being done within their individual function. Matrix organizations or dotted lines are too hard to get right.

1. The advantage of a functional structure is that you get better feedback and training since your manager understands your work better than a general manager.

1. For the organization, forgoing a separate class of managers ensures a simple structure with clear responsibilities.

1. A functional organization structure mimics the top structure of our organizations (Finance, Sales, Engineering, etc.).

1. It reduces compensation costs, coordination costs, and office politics.

1. The disadvantage is that your manager has a limited amount of time for you and probably has less experience managing people.

1. To mitigate these disadvantages we should offer ample training, coaching, support structures, and processes to ensure our managers can handle these tasks correctly and in a limited amount of time. "It's easier to train an expert to manage well than to train a manager to be an expert" from How Apple is organized for Innovation.

1. Everyone deserves a great manager that helps them with their career. A manager should hire a great team, should let you know when to improve, motivate and coach you to get the best out of you.

1. "Nuke all matrices. Nuke all dual reporting structures. And nuke as many shared services functions as you possibly can." from the great guide to big companies from Marc Andreessen (the other guides are awesome too).

1. We recommend reading High Output Management, and its author coined Grove's law: All large organizations with a common business purpose end up in a hybrid organizational form. We believe a dual reporting structure is inevitable, we just want to delay it as long as possible.

1. We do make features with a DevOps stage group that is a collection of teams and stable counterparts.

1. Whenever there is need to work on a specific, high-level, cross functional business problem, we can assemble a working group.

1. Functional companies are easier when you focus on one product. Apple focuses on the iPhone and can have a unitary/functional/integrated organizational form. The advantage is that you can make one strong integrated product. We can also maintain a functional organization as long as

we keep offering new functionality as features of GitLab instead of different products. The fact that we're in touch with the market because we use our own product helps as well.

1. Leaders should know the details of their organization three levels down for efficient and effective cross-functional decision-making.

1. Having functional managers means that they are rarely spending 100% of their time managing. They always get their hands dirty. Apart from giving them relevant experience, it also focuses them on the output function more than the process. Hopefully both the focus and not having a lot of time for process reduces the amount of politics.

1. Functional managers spend their time between owning, learning, delegating or teaching styles. Managers will decide what activities demand their full attention and fall within their core area of expertise which they will own and what activities require them to learn new areas of expertise. Some activities require less attention from the leader and can be pushed down to others by either delegating or teaching someone on the team.

SECTION: leadership/skip-levels.md

Purpose and Benefits of Skip-Levels

A skip-level meeting is a meeting during which a manager's manager meets directly with team members without the direct manager present. While 1-1s facilitate communication between a team member and their manager, skip levels should facilitate communication between the leader's whole team, not just their direct reports.

The CEO conducts quarterly skip-level meetings with all indirect reports. The goal of this meeting is to help the CEO be a better manager of him/herself, of the report of their function, and the rest of the executive team. What is going well, what needs improvement, how can the CEO help, and what should the CEO focus on when coaching the report?

It also gives the skips and senior leaders an opportunity to:

- Get to know each other and build rapport
- Provide an opportunity to have contributions recognized by a senior leader
- Ask questions
- Clarify their understanding of company or functional objectives

What Skip-Levels Are Not

It's important to note that the following are not purposes for the skip level meetings:

- To check in on the performance of a manager by "going around them."
- To manage priorities, career management, or perform any duties typically handled by a team member's direct manager.

Conducting skip level meetings

1. If your reports have multiple reports, a skip level meeting is required.

1. The skip level meeting is never recorded as it is a way to build trust with the team members.
1. Skip level meetings should be held at least quarterly. Whether or not you choose to organize them more frequently is at your discretion, and likely impacted by the number of skips you have.
1. Skip level meetings can be conducted one-on-one or in groups of no more than 10-15 (to encourage participation). You may prefer one approach over the other, or if you have too many skips one-on-one meetings may not be feasible.
1. If you're able to do one-on-one skip levels, we recommend the first meeting with each skip be similar to a coffee chat - a free-form discussion with the intent to get to know each other.
1. Aside from any of these free-form initial skip levels, subsequent meetings should have a clear agenda. The first portion of the agenda should include anything you want to update or reinforce with your skips - review strategy, remind the team about areas of focus, etc. After that, there should be ample time for questions from the skips.
1. In order to recognize team members and highlight the visibility of their work, consider preparing for a skip by reviewing accomplishments of the attendees ahead of time and documenting those at the beginning of the agenda.
1. Don't worry about repeating information in skip level meetings. One of the most common reactions managers have after they conduct skip levels is to say "I thought everybody knew that!" Remember that messages often have to be shared several times in several ways before they are communicated effectively.
1. Skip level meetings can also be a great place to solicit feedback from your skips. SKS questions, among other feedback mechanisms, make solid agenda items.

Having a large organization is not a reason to not conduct skip-level meetings. Senior leaders with a large organizations can opt to conduct skip-levels in a rotational fashion. If meeting with everyone is not scalable, instead meet with a new group of skip-level team members each quarter (or more frequently).

Learning From the CEO on Skip Level Meetings

{{< youtube "kAxp0Mam-Rw" >}}

Other Resources

- Skip Levels podcasts on Manager-Tools
- The Art of the Skip Level Meeting
- Skip Level Meetings

SECTION: leadership/underperformance.md

Introduction

We want all our team members to be successful! We continuously strive to maintain a high

standard of performance across the entire company and we are here to support our people leaders and team members along the way. We encourage regular and transparent communication across all areas of the business. We also fully recognize and accept that team members who do not meet the sustained performance expectations may be more successful at another company and we fully support those difficult conversations and decisions.

In all cases, we want a manager who asks the question "Is this the best person I could hire today?" to respond with a "Yes".

Managing Underperformance Handbook Learning Session

Managing and identifying underperformance can be one of the most difficult responsibilities of a manager, but it's also one of the most important. As a people leader, fairness and transparency is essential with all team members, as is addressing performance or conduct concerns in a timely and structured way. You will be introduced to the signs to look for to identify underperformance, and we cover tips team members and managers can implement along the way.

Managing Performance at GitLab

GitLab strives to treat all team members with dignity and respect at all times. You can review GitLab's Team Member Relation Philosophy which outlines how we treat all team members and provides guidelines for how we address issues within GitLab. The kindest thing we can do for our team members is to address any issue early and to provide a supportive environment where they can improve their performance. Failure to act early can greatly affect the performance of the team as a whole. Effective teams require cohesion, collaboration, and actively engaging and performing team members to be successful in reaching their goals. Without this cohesiveness, there is a risk to the overall team and GitLab's success.

Managing a team member who is underperforming is one of the more challenging aspects of the manager role. Though challenging, it is expected that all people leaders manage performance and provide team members with clear actionable feedback and guidance fairly and in a timely manner. Failure to appropriately address performance concerns in a timely manner is a reflection on the manager's performance, and has a negative impact on the manager, team member, other team members and the business.

GitLab uses the skill-based and will-based performance model to identify the root cause of the team members' underperformance and to determine the suitable remediation plan. The remediation plan will be based on the type of performance issue.

The Team Member Relations team is here to assist you in identifying the cause of the performance issue and can walk you through the performance management process that applies best to the situation. Below are definitions of skills-based and will-based concerns as well as the typical remediation plans. As with all situations, there may be unique circumstances that require unique remediation plans.

Inform the Team Member Relations Team

Looping in Team Member Relations early is essential. Team Member Relations can offer support, guidance, coaching, and partner with Legal to ensure compliance throughout all stages of the performance management process. Reaching out to the TMR team is critical to managing underperformance, and not doing so within a reasonable timeframe ultimately impacts the

manager's performance. Connecting with the TMR team ensures that feedback is being delivered in accordance with our guidance for giving feedback and within applicable local labor laws and regulations.

Warning Signs/Patterns of Underperformance

How do you know if a team member isn't reaching their goals? Below are some common warning signs and patterns of underperformance as it relates to not meeting the expectations of the role.

1. Lack of results
1. Response time delayed
1. Unclear status of work
1. Frustration toward the team
1. Regular disagreements or confusion about individual / team the goals
1. Extended team frustration- Frustration from other team members
1. Team dynamic - teamwork, communication, delivery being affected
1. Other team members start working around them
1. Missed goals and timelines

These are all signs of a performance issue, however, are these performance issues skill-based or will-based? Knowing the root cause of the performance issue enables the manager and team member to have open and transparent conversations to implement a plan to improve performance.

Skills-based performance

Team members may have the motivation to be successful but performance is impacted due to the possible following reasons:

- A lack of technical capability to be successful in their current role
- A lack of soft skills/emotional intelligence to be effective in their current role
- Inability to prioritize work effectively
- Lack of understanding of how to complete tasks required for role

People Leaders continuously review skill-based performance and can identify where issues may arise. They can then determine if the team member requires additional support in the form of coaching (verbal / written), specific training, additional tools/resources, guidance or assigning the team member a mentor or buddy for an agreed period of time.

Will-based performance

Team members who have the skills necessary to succeed in their current role but they lack the will to perform which can be evident in the following ways:

- Lack of motivation or not fully engaged
- Unprofessional behavior, actions or communication towards fellow team members
- Undesirable behavior that impedes the success of another Team member, Team or GitLab as a whole

If a manager or any team member witnesses or is made aware of any team member behavior that

violates our Code of Conduct they should immediately reach out to Team Member Relations at teammemberrelations@gitlab.com.

Team Member: Discuss Circumstances Immediately With Your Manager

Tell your manager immediately if there are circumstances in your life that cause you to be less effective. It isn't required to give details if you prefer not to. Tell your manager when it started, to what extent it hinders your work, and what your forecast is for your circumstances to improve. When you delay this conversation until your manager identifies underperformance you've lost trust that would be helpful during this period. Team Member Relations can also be a resource for team members experiencing circumstances that are affecting their performance.

Manager: Identify And Take Action As Early As Possible

The important thing to remember as a manager is to immediately address signs of underperformance. Taking action sooner allows more time for coaching to be effective and successful. In the early stage of the process it is important to identify the reasons why team members might not be meeting expectations for their role. We do this by reviewing previous performance history, ensuring the team member has been taking sufficient PTO (Paid Time Off) and also checking in to ensure all is well in their personal life and providing appropriate support when needed.

As you begin to coach, refer to resources in the handbook and from Elevate for support.

1. The GROW coaching model (As managers begin to coach, refer to important coaching resources in the handbook, also taught in Elevate:)
2. Managing your Inner Fixer
3. The Trust Equation
4. Essential Coaching Skills

Immediately Discuss With The Manager's Manager

Taking early action to address underperformance is an essential manager skill and one of the most important ways to improve results. As a people leader, it is best practice to inform your manager as a priority when you've identified possible underperformance and always tell us the bad news promptly. When a manager informs their leader, they can work together to ensure that underperformance is identified and that appropriate and agreed action is taken to address it.

Frequency and Metrics

We expect at least 5% of our team members to experience explicit performance management on an annual basis, and we expect more than 50% to be successful. We track this in meetings like the People Group Key Review and People Group Metrics to make sure we're managing performance consistently and fairly across all divisions, and in all circumstances. However, we don't enforce any hard thresholds.

This results in a lower rate of involuntary attrition than comparable companies, which range from 5 to 15% annually. We justify this based on the up-front effort we put into the hiring process. Divisions have various quantitative and qualitative processes for ensuring new hires can be successful at GitLab. This includes, but is not limited to:

- Requiring two "strong yes" votes from the interview team to make an offer
- Requiring that candidates demonstrate all documented must-have criteria for the role
- Requiring that candidates demonstrate a simple majority of all nice-to-have criteria for the role
- Requiring that hiring managers write a "justification" scorecard that outlines the candidate's strengths, outlines their weaknesses, and articulates a plan for making them successful
- Requiring that hiring managers fill out a retrospection document for all unsuccessful hires

Options For Remediation

Remediation options will vary based on whether the identified underperformance is due to a skill-based or will-based issue (and also in line with local applicable laws and regulations). The expectation is that all team members are provided coaching and feedback prior to the decision to exit the team member. However, it is important to note that in many cases we will not offer formal performance remediation or PIPs and will move to a separation with the team member if performance has not improved after documented coaching and feedback sessions. This is due to the critical impact of underperformance on the team and on the organization and allows us to maintain our results focused and high performing culture.

Coaching

Coaching is the preferred option to deal with underperformance and is the first step in addressing performance issues.

Managers are expected to address performance concerns (skill-based or will-based) in a timely manner. Managers should address concerns verbally during one-on-one meetings or in impromptu private coaching sessions with their team members. These conversations must be documented by the manager and shared with the team member so that both have access to the record of the discussion and are in alignment on where improvements need to be made and within a specified timeframe. Documentation should be brief (a few key bullet points or a paragraph), and will normally be sent via email to the team member following the verbal discussion. See the example coaching email below:

Underperformance feedback should be included on your 1-1 agenda. Helping GitLab team members understand clearly how their performance is below the expected standard expected quickly is very important to foster immediate improvement and continued success. Managers should be as specific as possible and provide clear examples of where the team member is falling short. Make sure the team member has the opportunity to respond to your concerns and give them the time to explain their performance. Keep an open mind, listen actively, and ask open questions when you want to find out more. When discussing performance, it's important that the manager and team member are aligned on the expectations moving forward. It is best practice for the manager to meet with their team member at least once a week to monitor and discuss their performance. be critical.

There may be extenuating circumstances that need to be taken into consideration during the performance management process. This is an area where the Team Member Relations Team can provide a sounding board or a needed perspective.

Written Performance Letters and Performance Improvement Plans

In some cases, a Written Performance Letter or Performance Improvement Plan may be considered as an option for performance remediation (and could be a requirement depending on local legislation). Managers should work with Team Member Relations to understand the use of these tools and any statutory requirements based on the location.

Compensation Impact

It is important to note that the team member may not be eligible for compensation increases from the annual compensation review or the annual refresh grant program if they are being actively performance managed.

Internal Applications and Transfers during underperformance remediation

When in the process of underperformance remediation you are generally not eligible for transfer to other roles within GitLab. If the underperformance is exclusively a result of a skills mismatch (not of lack of motivation, commitment, delivery etc. or misalignment to our values) other roles within GitLab may be considered, however, a determination regarding your eligibility is at the discretion of your manager and People Business Partner.

When the underperformance is resolved and you want to transfer to another role, please review the Internal Application Process for transfer. Please note that an internal reference will be conducted before the transfer is final, with this the documented underperformance may be discussed.

Talent Assessment and managing underperformance

Managers need to be aware and take into consideration both skill-based and will-based performance issues when they are participating in the Talent Assessment Performance/Potential Matrix process as listed in the handbook. It is critical that a manager consider these performance issues when evaluating a team member. If a team member is technically performing in their role but there are will-based performance issues that are impacting their ability or the team's ability to succeed, these need to be taken into consideration.

Letting Someone Go

This should be discussed with Team Member Relations before any action is taken to ensure the process is compliant with local laws and regulations. As soon as it becomes apparent that a Team Member will be off-boarded from the company, we recommend that this is addressed immediately. The team member is entitled to know where they stand. Delaying the conversation causes problems with confidentiality (the Team Member may realize in another way, that they will be exiting the company) and can potentially escalate the issues for the team member, the manager and the wider team (working relationships could be greatly affected).

SECTION: leadership/workforce-planning.md

Workforce planning is the strategic alignment of a division/departments team members with its

strategic goals. It is a methodical process of analyzing the current team member role alignments, determining future team member needs, identifying the gap between the present and future, and implementing solutions so the division/departments can accomplish its mission, goals, and objectives. Simply stated it is a way to align the right team members and skills at the right place and time for the right business outcomes.

For Workforce planning to be strategic the efforts should

- Align with GitLab business strategy
- Differentiate roles by their contribution to the overall achievement of the GitLab and Division strategy
- Focus first on the roles that have the most significant impact to GitLab and Division business strategy
- Leverages both qualitative and quantitative metrics of the workforce in both its current state and the future state perspectives

Steps for organizational alignment

There are four steps to working through organizational alignment. Leaders should work through these steps in order to help build and drive an action plan for the future.

1. Scan of the Environment - As you scan the environment in which your division/department functions, you will gather data needed for team member planning. Later, you will apply this data with your planning efforts. Environmental scanning examines internal and external Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats (SWOT). Budget will also be a major factor in the review.
1. Supply and Demand Analysis - The supply and demand analysis is based on the scan of your environment (SWOT) strategies, and operational direction. Supply and demand analysis will allow you to assess whether there is balance in the division/department. You will be able to determine whether there are imbalances among the workloads, team members and competencies that may exist now or in the future.
1. Gap Analysis - Gap analysis compares information from the supply and demand analysis to identify the differences between the current and the future division/department workloads, team members and skills/competencies.
1. Action Plan - Action plans should be developed to address the most critical gaps facing your divisions/department workforce and division/department strategy. Each division/department should determine its own action plan based on the relationship between GitLab strategy and the gaps identified. Depending on the gaps, the action plan may address some or all aspects for team members including, recruitment, compensation, training, performance management, succession planning, diversity, inclusion and belonging, quality of work life, retention, etc.

SWOT

The SWOT analysis helps divisions/department assess issues within and outside of GitLab. The SWOT analysis is made up of an assessment of strengths, weaknesses, external opportunities and threats from competition and provides an outline for strategic decision making.

Strengths

- Characteristics that give GitLab an advantage over others

- What is GitLabs value proposition, how does it differentiate with our competitors?
- What do others perceive as GitLabs strenghts?

Weaknesses

- Characteristics that place GitLab at a disadvantage relative to others
- What do our competitors do better than GitLab?
- What do others perceive as GitLabs weakness?

Opportunities

- What are the elements GitLab or (department/division) could use to its advantage?
- What trends or conditions exist that may positively impact GitLab?

Threats

- What are the elements in the environment that could cause trouble for GitLab or (department/division)?
- What trends or conditions may negatively impact GitLab?

A template has been provided here for reference SWOT slides

Supply and Demand Analysis

This is the step to evaluate the future needs of the division/departments. Future needs will be assed and determined on the answers to the following questions:

- How essential is each role?
- What job functions, if any, could be consolidated?
- How many team members are needed in the future to perform each job/role?
- What knowledge, skills, compentencies and abilities are needed to perform the anticipated job/roles?
- What processes could be done more efficiently or effectively?
- What technology changes will or should be made?
- Are there opportunities to realign resources?
- What are the division/departments strategic objectives?
- What are the division/departments diversity objectives?

Workforce Gaps, Risk Analysis and Action Planning

Workforce Gaps

A gap analysis is a review an assessment of your current department/divisions performance to help identify the differences between your current state and where you'd like to be. A gap analysis can help improve the division/department efficiencies, the product